



# THE FOLLICULAR PHASE

## What Happens Before Ovulation?

The follicular phase is the first major phase of the menstrual cycle. It begins on the first day of menstruation and ends at ovulation, when an ovary releases a mature egg.

This phase is called the follicular phase because it involves the growth of follicles in the ovaries. During this phase, the body prepares one egg for possible release and thickens the uterine lining in case pregnancy occurs later in the cycle.

## When Does the Follicular Phase Happen?

The follicular phase starts on day 1 of the menstrual cycle and continues until ovulation.

In many people, it lasts about 14 to 21 days, but the exact length can vary. Because of this, the follicular phase often explains why one person's cycle may be shorter or longer than another person's.

## What Happens During the Follicular Phase?

- Menstruation begins
- Follicles begin to develop in the ovaries
- One egg usually becomes dominant and matures
- Estrogen rises and thickens the uterine lining
- A surge in LH triggers ovulation

## Why the Follicular Phase Is Important

The follicular phase is essential because it prepares:

- The egg for release
- The uterus for possible implantation

This phase is also important in cycle tracking because the most fertile days occur near the end of it.

## Fertility During the Follicular Phase

A person is most likely to become pregnant near the end of the follicular phase, especially in the five days before ovulation and on the day of ovulation.

This is because sperm can survive for up to five days, while the egg survives for only about 12 to 24 hours after ovulation.

## Signs of the Follicular Phase

- Some people may notice:
- Lower basal body temperature before ovulation
- Cervical mucus becoming clearer, wetter, and more slippery closer to ovulation

## When to Speak With a Healthcare Provider

You may want to speak with a provider if:

- Your cycles are very irregular
- You think you may not be ovulating
- You have difficulty getting pregnant
- Your periods suddenly change in pattern

## Key Takeaway

The follicular phase is the part of the menstrual cycle when the body prepares an egg for release and rebuilds the uterine lining after menstruation. Because the most fertile days occur near the end of this phase, understanding it can be especially helpful for people trying to conceive.

*Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.*

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